FORGE

PHASE 3 — PRACTICUM

Week 28 of 36

Mid-Point Check-In

Sessions 82–84

Week 28: Mid-Point Check-In

Facilitator Notes for Week 28

Your men are four weeks into the field with eight to go, so it is time for an honest look at where each one stands. Session 82 is a formal mid-point review: each man rates himself, hears your feedback in a short one-on-one, then sets two or three goals specific enough to measure. It is the honesty they have practiced since Week 1, now turned on their work as mentors. The week also adds something new. In Session 84 each man keeps his first community circle in his own dorm, using what he learned in Week 21. A circle has no lesson plan to hide behind, only a talking piece and a question, and it is how a mentor starts building the kind of culture that makes everyone in the dorm safer. Hold two things in mind. Complete the Facilitator Feedback Form for every man before Session 82. And bring a timer: you have four or five minutes with each man, and longer talks can wait.

What to Watch For

Self-assessment accuracy: Compare each participant's self-assessment to your own observations. Participants who rate themselves too high may lack self-awareness. Participants who rate themselves too low may be struggling with confidence or depression. Both deserve a conversation.

Response to feedback: How participants receive feedback tells you a lot about their readiness. Watch for:

- **Defensive reactions** — "That's not fair" / "You don't see everything I do." These participants need the most growth in accountability. Be patient but don't back down.
- **Immediate agreement with everything** — "You're right, you're right, you're right." This might be people-pleasing, not genuine reflection. Push: "Which of these surprises you? Which one do you disagree with?"
- **Genuine engagement** — "I didn't realize I was doing that. Tell me more." This is what you're looking for.

Community circle anxiety: Running a circle in their own dorm — where they live, where their reputation exists, where people know them as inmates, not mentors — is different from facilitating in an assigned session room. Some participants will be anxious about looking "soft" or being mocked. Address this directly: "The men in your dorm have seen you go to class three times a week for six months. They've watched you change. Some of them are curious. Give them a chance."

Hours tracking: Some participants may be behind on their 60-hour requirement. By Week 28, they should have approximately 25-30 hours logged. If someone is significantly below that, create a plan to catch up — additional mentee meetings, extra community circles, or more facilitation opportunities.

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Common Week 28 Challenges

"My feedback was worse than I expected." Handle with care. "The feedback isn't about who you are — it's about where you are. Nobody expects perfection at the midpoint. The question is whether you're growing. And the fact that you're sitting here, hearing this, and not walking away — that tells me you are."

"I don't know how to run a circle in my dorm." They do know how — they learned in Week 21, they've participated in circles since Week 1, and they've been in one every week for six months. What they're really saying is: "I'm scared." Respond to what's underneath: "You know how to do this. What you're feeling isn't lack of knowledge — it's the weight of doing something meaningful in front of people who know you. That weight is real. Do it anyway."

"Nobody came to my circle." This happens. First circles are often small — 3-4 people is normal. Coach: "That's not failure. That's a start. Three men who were willing to sit in a circle in a prison dorm — that's remarkable. Next week, those three might bring one friend each. Culture change doesn't start with a crowd. It starts with a circle."

"My mentee is making real progress." Celebrate this. Many participants will be so focused on problems that they don't recognize wins. When someone reports genuine progress — a mentee who opened up, who used a skill, who made a different choice — acknowledge it in front of the group. "This is what you've been training for. This is what mentoring looks like when it works."

The Facilitator Feedback Form

Complete one for each participant BEFORE Session 82. Base it on:

- Observation notes from co-facilitation/observation sessions
- Mentoring log reviews from Weeks 25-27
- Participation in supervision sessions (case presentations, engagement, honesty)
- Informal observations (interactions with cohort, behavior between sessions)
- Senior mentor input (if applicable)

Form structure mirrors the self-assessment:

- Mentee Relationships: 1-5 rating + specific observations
- Facilitation Skills: 1-5 rating + specific observations
- Self-Management: 1-5 rating + specific observations
- Professional Practice: 1-5 rating + specific observations
- Overall assessment: Greatest strength, most critical growth area, readiness level

Readiness levels (for facilitator's internal use — not shared with participant as a label):

- **On track:** Meeting expectations for midpoint. Continue current trajectory.

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- **Needs support:** Struggling in 1-2 areas. Specific interventions needed.
- **At risk:** Significant concerns. May need modified plan, additional mentoring, or honest conversation about readiness.

Preparation for Week 28

- Prepare Mid-Point Review forms for each participant
- Review all mentoring logs from Weeks 25-27 — prepare written feedback
- Review co-facilitation/observation notes from Weeks 25-27
- Identify areas of strength and areas for growth for each participant
- Prepare community circle introduction for Session 84 in Week 28
- Calculate mentoring hours logged to date — are participants on track for the 60-hour requirement?

Week 28 Overview

Purpose: Week 28 marks the midpoint of Phase 3. Participants have been in the field for four weeks — long enough to have real data on how they're doing, what's working, and what needs to change. This week is about honest assessment: not grades, not judgment, but a clear-eyed look at where each person stands. The supervision session is a formal mid-point review. The Session 84 field work introduces a new responsibility: the first community circle in their assigned dorm.

Sessions This Week:

- Session 82: Supervision — Mid-Point Review
- Session 83: Field Work — Leading with Observation
- Session 84: Field Work — Mentee Meetings + First Community Circle

Materials Needed:

- Mid-Point Self-Assessment Form (1 per participant)
- Facilitator Feedback Form (1 per participant — completed by facilitator in advance)
- Mentoring Logs from Weeks 25-27 (participants bring theirs; facilitator has reviewed copies)
- Mentoring Hours Tracker (1 per participant)
- Community Circle Planning Template (1 per participant)
- Journals/notebooks
- Talking piece for circle

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SESSION 82: Mid-Point Review

Duration: 2 hours
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor(s)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Honestly assess their own performance across the first four weeks of Phase 3
2. Receive feedback without defensiveness and incorporate it into a growth plan
3. Identify their top strength and their most critical area for development
4. Set 2-3 specific goals for the remaining eight weeks
5. Articulate what they need from supervision to reach their goals

Session 82 Checklist

- ☐ Opening circle completed
- ☐ Mid-Point Self-Assessment forms distributed and completed
- ☐ Mentoring logs reviewed — general observations shared with group
- ☐ Mentoring Hours Trackers distributed — each participant knows their total
- ☐ Individual feedback conversations completed with each participant (4-5 min each)
- ☐ Goals finalized and shared with group (2-3 per participant)
- ☐ Community Circle Planning Template distributed and explained
- ☐ First community circle expectations set for Session 84
- ☐ Closing circle completed
- ☐ Any participants needing additional support identified for follow-up

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"We're at the midpoint of Phase 3. Four weeks in, eight weeks to go. Today is about taking stock — honestly. Not performing. Not pretending everything is great. Not catastrophizing everything that's hard. Just looking clearly at where you are.*
>
> *Talking piece. Short check-in:* ***One word that describes your mentoring right now.****"*

Send the talking piece. Keep it brief. The session is dense — you need the time for reviews.

The Mid-Point Self-Assessment (20 minutes)

Purpose: Participants evaluate themselves before receiving facilitator feedback.

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Before I share any of my observations, I want to hear yours. You're going to complete a self-assessment right now. This is the same honesty muscle you've been building since Week 1. Use it."*

Distribute the Mid-Point Self-Assessment Form. Participants complete it in writing (15 min).

Mid-Point Self-Assessment Form

Name: _____ Date: _____

Instructions: Rate yourself honestly on each area (1 = significant struggle, 3 = developing, 5 = strong). Then write a brief explanation.

A. Mentee Relationships

___ Building trust with mentees

> *Explain:* _____

___ Maintaining appropriate boundaries

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> *Explain:* _____

___ Using active listening and MI skills consistently

> *Explain:* _____

___ Following through on commitments to mentees

> *Explain:* _____

B. Facilitation Skills

___ Confidence leading/co-leading sessions

> *Explain:* _____

___ Managing group dynamics (quiet members, disruptors, emotional moments)

> *Explain:* _____

___ Adapting in real time when the plan isn't working

> *Explain:* _____

___ Closing sessions clearly with takeaways and next steps

> *Explain:* _____

C. Self-Management

___ Awareness of my own triggers during mentoring

> *Explain:* _____

___ Managing my emotional reactions without letting them spill

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> *Explain:* _____

___ Practicing self-care consistently

> *Explain:* _____

___ Avoiding the Savior Trap and the Fixer Trap

> *Explain:* _____

D. Professional Practice

___ Keeping mentoring logs complete and on time

> *Explain:* _____

___ Using supervision effectively (presenting cases, asking for help)

> *Explain:* _____

___ Showing up prepared for every session and meeting

> *Explain:* _____

___ Maintaining FORGE standards in and out of sessions

> *Explain:* _____

E. Overall Reflection

What is your greatest strength as a mentor right now?

_____

_____

What is the area where you most need to grow?

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_____

_____

What has surprised you most about mentoring in the field?

_____

_____

What do you need from supervision for the remaining 8 weeks?

_____

_____

> **Facilitator (after 15 min):**
> *"Hold onto your self-assessment. We're going to use it in a few minutes."*

Mentoring Log Review (15 minutes)

Purpose: Review the mentoring logs as a group — not to embarrass anyone, but to reinforce the practice and identify patterns.

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Let's talk about your logs. I've reviewed every log submitted from Weeks 25 through 27. Here's what I'm seeing across the group."*

Share general observations — not individual call-outs:

- Quality patterns: Are logs detailed or surface-level? Are self-reflections honest?
- Consistency: Is everyone logging every meeting? Are there gaps?
- Concerns flagged: Are people using the "concerns" section, or leaving it blank every time?
- Plans for next meeting: Are people writing real plans or generic ones?

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Your mentoring log is not busywork. It's the record that proves you were there, that you were paying attention, and that you were growing. When you sit in front of the certification review board in eight weeks, these logs are evidence. More importantly — they're the tool that helps you be a better mentor week over week. If you write 'meeting went fine' every week, you're not using it. 'Meeting went fine' tells you nothing when you look back at it.*

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> *Write like you're coaching yourself. Because you are."*

Distribute the Mentoring Hours Tracker:

> *"You should also know where you stand on hours. Certification requires 60 hours of documented mentoring and facilitation. I've calculated your hours through Week 27. Take a look. If you're behind, we need to talk about how to get on track."*

Give participants a moment to review their hours. Address any who are significantly behind individually after the session.

Individual Feedback Conversations (40 minutes)

Purpose: This is the most important part of the session. Each participant receives direct, honest feedback from the facilitator.

> **Facilitator:**
> *"For the next part of the session, I'm going to meet briefly with each of you individually — about 4-5 minutes each. While you're waiting, I want you to do two things:*
>
> 1. *Review your self-assessment and your mentoring logs side by side. Do they tell the same story?*
> 2. *Start drafting your goals for the remaining eight weeks — at least two specific, measurable goals.*
>
> *While I'm meeting with people, Senior Mentor [name] will be available if you want to talk through your goals."*

Individual conversations (4-5 minutes each):

The facilitator meets with each participant using the Facilitator Feedback Form, which has been completed in advance based on observation notes, mentoring log reviews, and co-facilitation/observation reports.

Facilitator Feedback Conversation Structure:

> 1. ***Start with strengths (1 min):*** *"Here's what I see you doing well..." — Be specific. Reference actual moments: "In your Week 26 session, when the group went quiet, you held the silence for a full 15 seconds before asking a follow-up question. That takes discipline."*
> 2. ***Growth areas (1-2 min):*** *"Here's where I think you need to grow..." — Be direct but kind. Connect to observable behavior, not character. "Your logs show a pattern of giving advice rather than asking questions. In three of your last four meetings, you wrote that you 'told' your mentee what to do. How does that match what you know about MI?"*

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3. ***Compare with self-assessment (1 min):*** *"You rated yourself ___ on ___. I would have rated you ___. Here's why..." — Where participant and facilitator agree, affirm. Where they disagree, explore: "You rated yourself a 4 on boundaries. I'd say 3. Here's what I'm seeing that makes me say that."*
4. ***Goals discussion (1 min):*** *"Based on all this, what are your goals for the next eight weeks?" — Help them make goals specific. Not "be a better listener" but "Ask at least three open-ended questions per mentee meeting and note them in my log."*

If the conversation reveals a serious concern:

- A participant who is struggling significantly may need a modified plan
- This could include additional observation, more frequent check-ins, or in rare cases, a conversation about readiness
- Handle with dignity: "I believe in your potential. I also believe you need more support in ___. Here's what I'm proposing."

Important: Keep to time. If you have 10 participants, 4-5 minutes each takes 40-50 minutes. Have a timer. Participants who need more conversation can meet with you after the session.

Goal-Setting and Group Sharing (15 minutes)

Purpose: Participants set goals publicly and commit to them.

> **Facilitator (after all individual conversations):**
>
> *"You've assessed yourself. You've heard my feedback. Now — what are you going to do about it?*
>
> *Finalize 2-3 specific goals for the remaining eight weeks. Write them down. Make them concrete enough that we could measure them."*

Give 5 minutes to finalize goals.

Examples of good goals:

- "Ask at least three open-ended questions per mentee meeting and document them in my log."
- "Practice 4-4-4 breathing before every field session for the next four weeks."
- "Present at least one case in supervision every other week."
- "Complete my mentoring logs within one hour of each meeting, not the next day."
- "Hold at least one minute of silence per facilitation session instead of filling every pause."

Go-around (10 min): Each participant shares one goal with the group.

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> **Facilitator (after all have shared):**
>
> *"Write these down. I will too. We'll revisit them at Week 32. That's your next check-in. Between now and then — pursue these goals like they matter. Because they do."*

Community Circle Introduction (10 minutes)

Purpose: Preview Session 84's new responsibility.

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"One more thing before we close. In Session 84, in addition to your regular mentee meetings, you're going to run your first community circle in your assigned dorm.*
>
> *This is different from your facilitation sessions. A community circle isn't a class. It's not a lesson. It's a restorative practice — an opportunity for the men in your dorm to sit in a circle, check in with each other, and build the kind of culture that makes everyone safer.*
>
> *You learned circle keeping in Week 21. Now you do it for real."*

Distribute the Community Circle Planning Template.

> *"Use this template to plan your first circle. Keep it simple. The format:*
>
> 1. ***Opening** (3 min): Welcome, explain the circle process, ground rules (talking piece, speak from the heart, listen from the heart)*
> 2. ***Check-in round** (10-15 min): One question — keep it accessible. 'How's your week going?' 'What's one thing on your mind right now?'*
> 3. ***Topic round** (15-20 min): One question that invites reflection. 'What's one thing that would make this dorm better for everyone?' or 'What does respect look like in this space?'*
> 4. ***Closing round** (5 min): 'One word for how you're feeling right now.'*
>
> *Total: 30-45 minutes. Don't overshoot. Your first circle, the goal is simple: **people show up, people speak, people listen, nobody gets hurt.** That's a win.*
>
> *A few practical realities:*
>
> - *Not everyone will come. That's fine. Even 5-6 people is a circle.*
> - *Some people will mock it. Don't react. Run the circle with whoever's willing.*
> - *Some people will test the talking piece rule. Gently enforce it: 'I hear you — grab the piece when it comes around and share that.'*
> - *You're going to feel exposed. A facilitation session has a lesson plan to hide behind. A circle has nothing but you, a talking piece, and a question. That's why it's powerful."*

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Closing Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Four weeks done. You've met your mentees. You've facilitated real sessions. You've dealt with resistance, silence, boundary tests, and your own reactions. You've done everything we asked of you — and you're still standing.*
>
> *The back half of Phase 3 is where you stop being a practitioner and start being a mentor. The difference? A practitioner follows the plan. A mentor reads the room and does what's needed. You're crossing that line now.*
>
> *Closing round. Talking piece:* ***Knowing what you know now — four weeks in — complete this sentence: 'The kind of mentor I'm becoming is...'***

Send the talking piece.

> **Facilitator (closing):**
>
> *"Hold onto what you just said. Compare it to the commitment you made in Week 1, Session 3. Write them both down tonight. See how far you've come.*
>
> *Session 83 — leading with observation. Session 84 — mentee meetings and your first community circle.*
>
> *You're halfway home. Keep forging.*
>
> *Service Over Self."*

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SESSION 83: Field Work — Leading with Observation

Duration: 2 hours (session) + preparation and debrief time
Structure: Participant leads the session independently. Observer present but not co-facilitating.

Field Work Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will have:

1. Led their second independent session (with observer)
2. Incorporated feedback from mid-point review into their facilitation
3. Demonstrated progress toward at least one of their stated goals
4. Continued building confidence as an independent facilitator

Pre-Session Preparation Checklist

- ☐ Session plan fully prepared — reviewed at least twice
- ☐ Materials ready
- ☐ Reviewed mid-point feedback: What's the one thing I'm working on today?
- ☐ Reviewed goals set in Session 82: How will I practice my goal during this session?
- ☐ Discussed with observer: What should they watch for today based on my goals?
- ☐ Self-care practice completed
- ☐ 4-4-4 breathing completed
- ☐ "What if" scenarios mentally rehearsed

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Post-Session Debrief (with observer)

This week, the debrief should reference the mid-point review:

Observer addresses:

1. Did the participant demonstrate improvement in their identified growth area?
2. What evidence of goal progress did you observe?
3. What remains the priority for development?

Participant reflects:

1. Which of my goals from Session 82 did I practice today? How did it go?
2. What felt different about this session compared to Session 80?
3. Where do I still feel uncertain?
4. What do I want to work on next week?

Field Work Reflection Prompts

Complete in your journal after the session:

1. **How did the mid-point feedback show up in today's session? Were you more aware of your growth areas?**
2. **Describe a moment where you made a choice as a facilitator — not just followed the plan, but actually chose how to respond to something in the moment. What did you choose and why?**
3. **Are you starting to develop your own facilitation style? What does it look like? How is it different from how you were taught?**
4. **Rate your confidence as an independent facilitator on a scale of 1-10. What would move you up one point?**

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SESSION 84: Field Work — Mentee Meetings + First Community Circle

Duration: Mentee meetings (45-60 min each) + Community circle (30-45 min)
Structure: Regular mentee meetings followed by the first community circle in assigned dorm

Field Work Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will have:

1. Continued mentee meetings with focus on mid-point adjustments
2. Facilitated their first community circle in their assigned dorm
3. Experienced the difference between structured facilitation and circle keeping
4. Logged all activities in the Mentoring Log (template from Week 25)

Pre-Session Preparation Checklist — Mentee Meetings

- ☐ Reviewed Mentoring Logs from last week
- ☐ Identified follow-up items for each mentee
- ☐ Set goal for each meeting based on mid-point review feedback
- ☐ If any mentee relationship needs adjustment based on mid-point review, prepared approach
- ☐ 4-4-4 breathing completed before each meeting

Pre-Session Preparation Checklist — Community Circle

- ☐ Community Circle Planning Template completed (from Session 82)
- ☐ Location identified — where will the circle happen? Is there enough space for chairs in a circle?
- ☐ Time communicated — does the dorm know when and where?
- ☐ Talking piece selected (meaningful object — book, stone, or anything the circle can respect)
- ☐ Opening question prepared (accessible, non-threatening)
- ☐ Topic question prepared (reflective but not too heavy for a first circle)
- ☐ Closing question prepared

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- ☐ Mental rehearsal: What will you do if no one comes? If someone mocks the process? If the circle goes sideways?
- ☐ Reminded yourself: The goal is not perfection. The goal is: people show up, people speak, people listen.

Community Circle Planning Template

Circle Keeper: _____

Date: _____ **Time:** _____

Location: _____

Expected participants: _____ (number)

Opening (3 minutes)

How will you welcome people?

_____

Ground rules you'll establish:

- ☐ Only the person holding the talking piece speaks
- ☐ Speak from the heart
- ☐ Listen from the heart
- ☐ Say just enough
- ☐ What's shared here stays here (with safety exceptions)
- ☐ You can pass

Check-in round question:

_____

Topic round question:

_____

Closing round question:

_____

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After the circle — reflect:

How many people attended? _____

How did the circle go overall?

_____

_____

What worked?

_____

What was challenging?

_____

Would you change anything for next time?

_____

How did it feel to hold space for a group in your dorm — not as a facilitator teaching content, but as a circle keeper?

_____

_____

Bring this template to supervision in Session 85.

Meeting Guidance for Week 4

This week's focus: Adjusting based on mid-point review.

> *By now, you've met with each mentee three times. You should have a sense of who they are, what they need, and where the relationship is heading.*
>
> *This week, apply your mid-point feedback to your meetings:*
>
> - *If your feedback was about asking more questions, set a mental target for open-ended questions during each meeting.*
> - *If your feedback was about boundaries, notice where boundary moments arise and hold them firmly.*
> - *If your feedback was about slowing down, pause intentionally during each meeting — let silence do its work.*

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> *Also: share the concept of the community circle with your mentees. Invite them. Having your mentees present at your first circle builds their investment in the community culture you're creating.*

Field Work Reflection Prompts

Complete in your journal after all meetings and the community circle:

1. **How did the mid-point review change how you showed up for your mentee meetings today? Be specific.**
2. **Describe your first community circle. What happened? How did it feel? What surprised you?**
3. **How was circle keeping different from facilitating a session? What skills were the same? What was different?**
4. **You're now four weeks into Phase 3. Looking back at who you were on the first day of the program — Week 1, Session 1 — what has changed? Write at least half a page.**
5. **What's one question you have that you haven't asked yet in supervision? Write it down and commit to bringing it to Session 85.**

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